

Minor Keys & Borrowed Chords

Every major key has a minor twin

They use the **same notes**. Only the "home" chord changes.

- C major ↔ **A minor**
- G major ↔ **E minor**

A song feels minor when the **minor chord is home** — where phrases start and rest.

Same chords, different home:

- C – G – Am – F → home is C → sounds **major**
 - Am – F – C – G → home is Am → sounds **minor**
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Minor loops

In minor, the numbers change to match the new home. Try each and write a mood word.

1. **i – VI – III – VII** — Am F C G / Em C G D — Mood: _____
2. **i – VII – VI – VII** — Am G F G / Em D C D — Mood: _____
3. **i – iv – VI – V** — Am Dm F E / Em Am C B — Mood: _____

(In loop 3, the **V** is major — E instead of Em, B instead of Bm. It pulls hard back to home.)

Minor doesn't just mean sad. It can be mysterious, angry, determined, epic, or hype.

Borrowed chords

A song in major can borrow **one** chord from the minor key for a flash of color.

Chord	In C	In G	Feeling	Try this
iv (minor four)	Fm	Cm	Bittersweet, nostalgic	C – F – Fm – C
♭VII (flat seven)	B♭	F	Big, rock, triumphant	C – B♭ – F – C
♭VI (flat six)	A♭	E♭	Cinematic, heroic	C – A♭ – B♭ – C

The last one (♭VI – ♭VII – I) is the **Mario cadence** — it ends the *Super Mario Bros.* level-complete fanfare.

Rule of thumb: one borrowed chord is color. Three starts to sound like a different key.

Playing them

Letter names (for the chord chart and GarageBand keyboard)

- Fm = F A♭ C
- B♭ = B♭ D F
- A♭ = A♭ C E♭
- E (major) = E G# B

Ukulele (G C E A strings, top to bottom)

- Fm = 1013
 - B♭ = 3211
 - A♭ = 1343
 - E = 1402, or the easier E7 = 1202
 - Key of G versions: Cm = 0333 · F = 2010 · E♭ = 0331 · B7 = 2322
 - Minor loops in A minor: Am 2000 · F 2010 · C 0003 · G 0232 · Dm 2210
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Color chords (bonus)

Add a seventh to any chord for a smoother, "lo-fi" or R&B sound (ukulele shapes in brackets):

- Cmaj7 = C E G **B** [0002]

- Fmaj7 = F A C **E** [2410]
 - Am7 = A C E **G** [0000]
 - Dm7 = D F A **C** [2213]
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My Song 2 progression: _____ - _____ - _____ - _____

Mood I'm going for: _____

Home chord: _____ (major / minor)